



» FIFA WORLD CUP BUMPER PERSPECTIVE

Making a splash: Mesut Ozil made a big impact as Germany finished third at the 2010 World Cup in South Africa. GETTYIMAGES

The value of visibility

For all the sophistication of modern scouting networks, nothing carries quite the **same weight** as excelling at a World Cup.

Anish Pathiyil

anish.p@thehindu.co.in

There is no grander stage in football than the FIFA World Cup. It is the theatre where dreams are realised, where adrenaline turns into ecstasy and, at times, effort into anguish. Despite all the accolades available at the club level, representing one's country at the quadrennial tournament remains the pinnacle of many players' careers. Just as importantly, it is often the biggest audition for those looking to take the next step.

Players who have lit up the World Cup have often been rewarded with life-changing transfers that propelled them into global superstardom. The most famous example is arguably James Rodriguez in 2014. A breakout tournament in Brazil, where he finished as the Golden Boot winner with six goals and helped Colombia reach the quarterfinals for the first time, paved the way for a big-money move to Real Madrid.

The attacking midfielder went on to win two UEFA Champions League titles and two La Liga crowns among a host of other honours as a modern-day galactico. Between those two league triumphs came a two-year loan spell at Bayern Munich, where he added five more trophies to his collection. There is, however, a caveat to the Rodriguez story. The Colombian had already been playing in Europe since 2010 and had won the Europa League with Porto before earning a move to AS Monaco, which was spending heavily following its return to Ligue 1.

A clearer example of the World Cup serving as a springboard is that of Mesut Ozil. The midfielder emerged through Schalke's academy before a contract dispute forced his departure to Werder Bremen, where he quickly established himself. The real leap in his career, however, came after the 2010 World Cup in South Africa. Ozil started every game for Germany, scored the winner against Ghana and provided three assists, the joint-highest tally in the

tournament. A move to Real Madrid followed, and he spent three seasons in the Spanish capital, winning the league title once.

This phenomenon of major transfers following a World Cup is far from new. One of the earliest examples came in 1963 when Amarildo moved from Botafogo to AC Milan. The striker played a key role in Brazil's 1962 World Cup triumph, particularly after Pele's injury, scoring three goals, including one in the final.

English starlet Alan Ball, the youngest member of England's 1966 World Cup-winning squad and the Player of the Match in the final, secured a British-record £112,000 move to Everton after the tournament.

Tomas Skuhravy is another player whose fortunes changed after a stellar World Cup campaign. The 6ft 4in Sparta Prague striker scored five goals for Czechoslovakia at Italia '90 and earned a move to Genoa, where he scored 59 goals across five seasons.

World Cups have also helped players climb the ladder later in their careers. Gheorghe Hagi earned a move to Real Madrid from Steaua Bucuresti after impressing at the 1990 World Cup. His career appeared to be heading in the opposite direction when he was sold to Brescia in 1992. However, three goals from midfield at the 1994 World Cup, helping Romania reach the quarterfinals, earned him a move to Barcelona at the age of 29.

The trend is set to continue at the upcoming edition of the tournament. Despite the sophisticated scouting networks employed by clubs around the world, a player who shines on football's biggest stage will always command attention. Cote d'Ivoire winger Yan Diomande, Argentine midfielder Nico Paz, England's Elliot Anderson, and Croatian defender Luka Vuskovic are among the next generation of players tipped for major moves in the near future.

A strong World Cup campaign will only strengthen their case and could prove the difference between a transfer to a mid-sized club and a move to European royalty.